

districts. The Reddys did not invite Yeddyurappa for the inauguration because of his reluctance to roll back his plan to tax mining trucks.

The Bellary deputy commissioner, the SP and other officials were transferred by Yeddyurappa, infuriating the brothers further, who wanted him to reinstate the officials and roll back his plan to collect toll from mining trucks. With the Centre not releasing the Rs 6,700 crore that Karnataka has been asking, Yeddyurappa has been looking for other ways to mop up the funds.

It is not that the Congress—with 74 seats in Karnataka and ready to sup with the Reddys who claim 50—is not willing to stitch up a coalition despite the chief minister stepping up operations against Reddy mining companies. In the political crisis—even Arun Jaitley failed to snuff out the initial fires in Bangalore—it is advantage Reddys. Not only because they have united all dissident voices against Yeddyurappa but also because of their ability to drag on the



MLAS IN THE REDDY CAMP NUMBER UP TO 50

crisis for over two weeks.

As Law Minister Suresh Kumar put it, "There are no winners, the only loser will be the party." The high command definitely does not want to pack off the first BJP Government in the south into oblivion. Karandlaje, meanwhile, has been taken off major

flood relief work, demonstrating that Yeddyurappa has blinked in the standoff with the Reddy brothers. But even if she is out of the Government, she is unlikely to be out of her patron's power circle. Janardhan has told the party high command that he is not looking at five years of BJP in Karnataka "but 50 years". Provided he gets Yeddyurappa's head. ■



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